

Queer Latinidad

IDENTITY PRACTICES

DISCURSIVE SPACES

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1 *Divas, Atrevidas, y Entendidas*

An Introduction to Identities

Identity is about situatedness in motion: embodiment and spatiality. It is about a self that is constituted through and against other selves in contexts that serve to establish the relationship between the self and the other. Places afford preexisting narratives of former encounters; they offer a means of symbolically decoding practices that occur within certain sociolinguistic frameworks. The subject brings to the encounter her own set of decoding practices that are mediated by the regulatory power of a particular discursive space, but not wholly determined by them. The discursive space does not establish which identity practices are available, but it does provide a frame through which these practices are received in that context. The subject's ability to subvert dominant readings is both unlimited and partial. The challenge becomes how to conceptualize subjectivity through both semiotic structures (discursive spaces) and agency (identity practices) by investigating the ways these fields work to constitute, inform, and transform one another.

Discursive spaces exist as sites of knowledge production. The clinic, the prison, the classroom construct fields of knowledge and have historically

existed to define subjects. Discursive spaces need not be institutional, however; the chatroom, the bar, the street corner, the computer screen also serve to define subjects and construct knowledge practices. These spaces have their own linguistic codes and reading practices, as they engage in hiding and revealing their own internal contradictions. Objects, art, texts, buildings, maps can also create knowledge, change history, refigure language. Decentralizing the subject in space does not erase her significance; instead it highlights the process through which subjects negotiate a localized time-space framework of knowledge. This work takes as its sites of analysis three contemporaneous spheres of discourse where questions of identity are centrally operative and where the contradictions revealed by their articulation emerge and are negotiated: activism, law, and cyberspace. In each of these contexts, the question "What is identity?" becomes transformed into "What is identity for?" Under what circumstances is it constructed and whose interests does it serve?

In "Conjugating Subjects in the Age of Multiculturalism," Norma Alarcón articulates how discourses on difference and identity create knowledge about subjects and the ways subjects speak back to create new bodies of knowledge. She states that "[t]he paradoxes and contradictions between subject positions move the subject to recognize, reorganize, reconstruct, and exploit difference through political resistance and cultural productions in order to reflect the subject-in-process" (138). Identity, therefore, is not merely a response to culturally defined differences, but is continually engaged in unpacking the stream of "paradoxes and contradictions" that inform the subject's relationship to other subjects and the discourses that surround them. Subjects mobilize identities and are in turn mobilized by those identity constructions. In a way, Alarcón's essay rearticulates the question "What is identity for?" by making central the implications for the competing discourses on "essentialism," "identity-in-difference," "multiculturalism," and the "cultural politics of difference." Drawing on the work of other feminists of color, she suggests that no single term or construct can fully inscribe the historically marginalized subject whose theoretical existence, insights, and

ideologies have been “thought out from the site of displacement” (136). Instead, she states that many feminists of color are engaged in a politics of “not yet” as a response to the multiple attempts to determine their subjectivity, even as they construct provisional identities, or what Chela Sandoval names “tactical subjectivities.” Alarcón’s own term, “subject-in-process,” simultaneously moves past the centrality and universality of the unified bourgeois subject or “man” and makes explicit the process through which individuals negotiate the critical terrains that attempt to fix the subject and “produce structures and discourses of containment that resist change” (137). The term “subject-in-process” does not insinuate a progressional, unidirectional development; instead the process is often spastic and unpredictable, continually unfolding without origin or end, an act of becoming that never ceases. Implicit in her method is the need to situate both the subject and the discourses surrounding subjectivity within a specific sociohistorical and geopolitical context, or what she names a “situated contemporaneous horizon of meanings” (137).

Discourse provides the context and the methodology through which both identity and this “horizon of meanings” can be interrogated. Subjects are continually involved in negotiating the accumulated narratives of identity that circulate within these localized “horizons of meanings” and the contradiction revealed within their articulations. Chela Sandoval describes this practice of negotiating “between and amongst” different discourses of identity and resistance as “differential consciousness,” an activity that “U.S. third world feminists” have developed and deployed as a response to hegemonic structures. She writes,

Differential consciousness is comprised of seeming contradictions and difference, which then serve as tactical interventions in the other mobility that is power. . . . Entrance into this new order requires an emotional commitment within which one experiences the violent shattering of the unitary sense of self, as the skill that allows a mobile identity to form takes hold. (225–26n. 25)

Identity is slippery stuff. The practices through which subjects construct identity are never singular. We move and speak in ever shifting contexts of meaning. The community forum, the courtroom, the Internet chatroom, the departmental meeting each shape how we talk about ourselves and interpret the words of others. We are continually being read; subjectivity becomes an object of interpretation. There is always an excess that destabilizes, transmutes, or coalesces what we think we know about ourselves or those around us. Manifestations of identity can be mapped within specific fields of knowledge, but cannot be contained by them.

In *The Archeology of Knowledge*, Foucault delineates archeology as a method of investigation. "In archeological analysis comparison is always limited and regional. Far from wishing to reveal general forms, archeology tries to outline particular configurations" (157). As a method, archeology takes theory and practice as simultaneous, with neither one as a preexisting condition or construction. Discourse does not uncover objects, it constitutes them, it takes as its object of analysis that which "'contains thought' in a culture," not a history of that thought or culture itself (*Foucault Live* 9). In this book promotional flyers, legal testimony, and Internet transcripts become the unruly subjects of academic investigation. Yet it is precisely their unsanctioned status as objects of inquiry that opens up interpretive possibilities for the representation of queer *latinidad*, as they announce the contradictory contours of the discursive spaces in which they emerge.

In defining the practice of archeological analysis, Foucault incessantly engages the site of contradiction as a nexus of knowledge.

By taking contradictions as objects to be described, archeological analysis does not try to discover in their place a common form or theme, it tries to determine the extent and form of the gap that separates them. In relation to a history of ideas that attempts to melt contradictions in the semi-nocturnal unity of an overall figure, or which attempts to transmute them into a general, abstract, uniform principle of interpretation

or explanation, archeology describes the different *spaces of dissension*. (*Archeology* 152)

Not to be understood as merely the location of resistance, these “spaces of dissension,” sites of contestation, unmask the process of effacement that makes both hegemonic and oppositional discourses appear unified and whole. The sites I have selected for analysis are not to be read as exceptional or unique instances of these contradictory spasms that yield new forms of knowledge; spaces of dissension sprout everywhere. My goal is to document the processes through which these moments of rupture are articulated and mobilized. Feminists of color have established the numerous ways that contentious oppositional discourses such as feminism, civil rights, and cultural nationalism have maintained themselves through erasure and the melding of contradictions (Alarcón; Lorde; Moraga). Similarly, it is these “spaces of dissension” within oppositional discourses that productively trouble the waters of queer *latinidad*.

Que(e)rying *Latinidad*

La búsqueda de América Latina: entre el ansia de encontrarla y el temor de no reconocerla. (Ansaldi)

I borrow the title of Waldo Ansaldi’s text, “The search for Latin America, between the angst of finding her and the fear of not recognizing her,” to suggest what it may mean to speak of queer *latinidad*.¹ The spastic contradictions and wild paradoxes of bodies and sites, identities and spaces intersecting are exemplified by the juxtaposition of these two terms, both provisional and immediate. Before attempting to unravel the implications and disjunctures of their union, let me turn first to the problematics involved in the construction of *latinidad*. Here different discourses of history, geography, and language practices collide. *Latinidad* serves to define a particular geopolitical

experience but it also contains within it the complexities and contradictions of immigration, (post)(neo)colonialism, race, color, legal status, class, nation, language, and the politics of location.² So what constitutes *latinidad*? Who is Latina? Is *latinidad* in the blood, in a certain geographic space? Is it about language, history, and culture, or is it a certain set of experiences?

The most common response to the question "Who is a Latina?" relies on a geographic reference. Contemporary maps of Latin America begin with México and end with the islands at the tip of Chile, with the Antilles cradled between the land masses of the north and south. Under this rubric a Latina would be a woman from Latin America, or of Latin American descent. Geographical namings, however, are constructed by history and politics, ignoring both the national boundaries of México before the 1848 Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo and the marginalized Indigenous ethnic communities throughout the Américas that refuse to be subsumed by occupying nation-states. The Mayans struggling for autonomy in Chiapas consider themselves culturally and politically separate from México; does that also constitute a separateness from the larger category of *latinidad*? What about the Indigenous tribes of the southwestern United States? Many tribal members (including those with Spanish surnames) reject a Chicano identity in favor of a Native one. How are national, ethnic, and cultural definitions of identity deployed within different geopolitical sites? How do these different deployments of identity contradict and inform one another?

National identity offers the most immediately available identity category for most Latin Americans, yet it also contains within it the contradictions inherent in any national project. Guillermo Gómez-Peña uses the example of Tijuana as a site "where so-called Mexican identity breaks down—challenging the very myth of national identity" (Fusco 156). A Mexican identity as such only makes sense outside a Mexican context. It is the experience of having to define one's sense of self in opposition to dominant culture that forces the creation of an ethnic/national identity that is then readable by the larger society. "Mexican" is a term that most English speakers understand; *Lacan-*

don, *chilanga*, or *norteco* is not. The myth of harmonious Mexican nationalism that masks ethnic and social multiplicity and conflict is reconsolidated on the other side of the border, often as a form of resistance to dominant Anglo-American culture. The constant translation between spaces is never absolute. The imposed necessity for “strategic essentialism,” reducing identity categories to the most readily decipherable marker around which to mobilize, serves as a double-edged sword, cutting at hegemonic culture as it reinscribes nation/gender/race myths on both sides of the border.

En el norte, Mexican identity can be again transformed to become Chicana identity. This new naming and its transmutations, Xicana and Xicaindia, make a claim from outside the space of national identity to assert a new culture born of Mexican, Anglo, and Indigenous hybridity. It also serves as a claim against U.S. occupation of Mexican and/or Indigenous lands; for many Chicanas/os the states of the U.S. Southwest are their ancestral lands. These are complex and contradictory claims, however: one cultural, articulated through a discourse of *mestizaje*; one tribal, grounded in the language of sovereign tribal rights. Manifestations of Chicano cultural nationalism usually invoke an Indigenous past to reclaim a mythical formation of the nation of Aztlán, but it is a path most often traced through the various incarnations of a Mexican nation-state.

The possibility of a “cultural identity” as a means of escaping the bonds of a univocal “national identity” may seem particularly useful for understanding *Chicanismo* and the cultural formations of other dislocated ethnic communities. Etienne Balibar writes, “[w]hat is called cultural identity is constantly compared to and at the limit conflated with *national identity*, and nevertheless is in some sense ‘sheltered’ from the empirical existence of nations, their borders, their politico-military history” (177). The relationship between these terms is further complicated by the relationship between the nation and the state, because “in practice, individuals ‘encounter’ the nation through the state (through an at least *possible* state) that ‘represents’ it, through the state’s institutions” (Balibar 177–78). The problem of how “cultural identity” is consolidated and written through and against other

discourses of nations, states, languages, and bodies, however, remains open to contradictory impulses and practices of erasure.

Questions of the history and implications of *mestizaje*, *mulatismo*, and their resistance and collusion with state and national narratives seem particularly relevant here and further complicate easy notions of cultural identity. These terms have often served as a means to construct a cultural identity in opposition to stratified colonial Anglo/Spanish/Indigenous/African formations, as well as a way to speak about our multihued families constructed through biology and affiliation. Yet racialized markings continue to serve as discrete and interrelated emblems that inform our individual locations within these familial and social *mestizo* constellations. Terms such as *pelo bueno* (good hair), which is straight or only slightly waved, and *pelo malo* (bad hair), which is kinky or tightly curled; *facciones finas* (fine features), particularly a thin pointed nose and narrow lips; *pies de indio* (Indian feet), used to describe feet that are wide and flat rather than thin and arched; *mancha de plátano* (plantain stain), visually marked as *mestizo*, serve as localized cultural codes for gradations of racialized bodies in Latin/o American vernaculars, retaining the colonial valorization of Europeans.

Spanish speakers, however, have a much richer vocabulary for characterizing physical appearance than do Anglo-Americans, and racial signifiers are often employed and read without biased intent. At times, words such as *negra* or *mulato* are used as generic names for woman and man regardless of the skin color of the referent. Yet these words possess powerful shadows that can be read and received only in context. *Mi negrita* can sound like the embrace of a mother or lover's voice, or as an echo of ownership and servitude. Other times racialized names like La India (the name of the popular Nuyorican *salsera*), El Gallego, El Chino, El Gringo come to replace given names, or to serve as a suffix to personal names. Yet El Gringo can refer to a Latino who merely "looks" like a gringo; El Gallego can be from Sevilla or be a descendent of any region of Spain; El Chino can in reality be Japanese or *mestizo*.³ These names or nicknames are not predetermined identifying labels, but descriptive or metaphorical representations that emerge and circulate in the

context of the familial and the familiar. These names illustrate the linguistic incorporation of the cultural consequences of centuries of immigration and *mestizaje*, but also signal their transformation and resignification within these sites.

In the service of nation building and cultural nationalism, however, *mestizaje* and *mulatismo* can effect the illusion that previous colonial racial categories are no longer operative. Coco Fusco writes,

It is a cliché to say that Latin America has resolved its problems of identity. What has actually happened is that the state has created ideologies that propose solutions to the problem of identity, but those solutions always occlude the existence of marginalized groups who are not part of the “national project.” In this sense, we cannot think that everyone in Cuba, Mexico, or Puerto Rico identifies with the official celebration of *mestizaje*. Things get even more complicated when we take into account that the official notion of *mestizaje* is connected to concepts of nationality and territoriality. (163)

Often both popular and official projects of *mulatismo* and *mestizaje* have been used to flatten or subsume differences, reinscribe margins, and uphold whiteness.⁴ As with national identity, these cultural identities are very often grounded in hetero-masculinist narratives and highly stratified categories of racialized gender.⁵

Within a Caribbean context the anomalies posed by a Latina/o “cultural identity” seem to multiply. If Dominicanas are Latinas, are Haitianas? Geographically they share the same island, *el mismo caribe*. And what can we say about those multilingual islands that defy easy classification: Aruba, Curaçao, Trinidad, are they part of *el mundo Latino*? Even when we think of South and Central America, do we forget the English- and Creole-speaking countries of Guyana, Surinam, and Belize, or the polylingual regions of Nicaragua, Costa Rica, and Panamá? How do we categorize the huge Portuguese-speaking anomaly of Brazil? If we decide that Spanish or at least a

shared linguistic “Latin” heritage is the common thread that unites us, it is a precarious thread indeed. Clearly there are other official and unofficial languages spoken in Latin/o America and the Caribbean: Quechua, Aymara, Guaraní, French, Hindi, Creole, Lucumi, Papiamentu, and English, to name a few. These languages remind us of the Indigenous past before successions of European colonizers, African enslavement afterwards, and centuries of transnational migration.

Perhaps it is precisely this shared legacy of Iberian colonization, massacres of Indigenous peoples, and slavery that defines *latinidad*. Yet Spain and Portugal also spread their colonial seeds elsewhere, in the Philippines, the Canary Islands, Cape Verde, Morocco, Macao, Mozambique, Guinea Bissau, and Angola, for example. In México, the mixture of Indigenous and Spanish blood is considered *mestizo*, yet in the Philippines this same mixture is considered Asian. Italians or Spaniards who immigrate to New York are considered European, but if they or their families migrate first to Argentina, Puerto Rico, or Venezuela and then come to New York, they are considered Latinos. What happens along the way? The cultural fusion of African and Portuguese brought about through enslavement may be considered Latino in Brazil, yet the same combination in Cape Verde is considered . . . something else.⁶

While much can be said about the particularities of Iberian colonialism versus the experiences of colonies under British, French, or Dutch rule, it is necessary to also consider the impact of serial colonialism. Brazil was under Dutch rule before being conquered by the Portuguese. Jamaica was a Spanish territory before becoming a British colony. The Philippines and Puerto Rico were Spanish colonies before they became U.S. territories. And of course, vast segments of the continental United States were previously claimed by the French, the Spanish, and México. National expansion, conquest, and annexation also meant successive tribal deterritorialization for Indigenous peoples throughout the Américas. These complex historical legacies intrude upon facile distinctions based on colonial characteristics as they shed light on a much longer narrative of multilingualism, transnational migration, and colonial geographic imaginings.

Ironically, several regions of the Iberian Peninsula also make claims to being unwilling subjects of Spanish colonialism and conquest. Euskal Herria, the Basque region that crosses the border between French and Spanish states, is home to an indigenous language, Euskera, of unascertained origin, and a cultural tradition rich in pre-Christian iconography and mythology. During the years of the Franco dictatorship, Basques suffered the violent repression of their indigenous culture, language, and traditions. Today certain Basque nationalist factions are engaged in political and armed rebellion for self-determination and autonomy from an occupying Spanish state. Populations in Galiza, Catalunya and Euskal Herria make varying claims for a cultural and linguistic identity separate from an imposed, culturally Castilian, Spanish nationalism, which has historically attempted to consolidate itself precisely through colonialism and conquest.⁷ Castilian, or *castellano*, is the language of empire; however, in most of Latin/o America it is commonly referred to as *español*, or Spanish, evidencing the conflation of language and nation achieved through the colonial project. Certainly, not all *vascos*, *gallegos*, and *catalanes* imagine themselves as colonial subjects. The very means by which imperial mandates operate create the conditions where collaboration, assimilation, and contestation as strategies of survival become absorbed as defining features of the colonizing project. Nevertheless, it appears that Iberian colonialism has created a web of cultural influence and domination many times larger than any recognizable concept of *latinidad*.

In the Américas the most glaring example of overt colonial occupation continues to be Puerto Rico, and here again the responses to that occupation represent a spectrum of political strategies. Unlike Chicanos and immigrants from Latin America, whose passage to ancestral or familial homeland is closely guarded by the U.S. border patrol, Puerto Ricans in the United States have unrestricted migratory access to their *isla del encanto*, allowing them to enjoy second-class citizenship both on and off the island. In the case of Puerto Rico, physical geography itself functions as an influential feature of political and cultural ideology. A clearly delineated national identity may be easier

to maintain in a small island state than in a larger territory with politically determined borders. Yet the proximity of the various islands of the Caribbean has also resulted in a long history of inter-island migration before, during, and after colonization. Today, Haitians cross the border to cut sugarcane in the Dominican Republic, Dominicans arrive illegally to work as domestics and laborers in Puerto Rico, Puerto Ricans journey north in search of new opportunities.

Yet, particularly within the existing climate of anti-immigrant legislation, Puerto Rico's unique political status vis-à-vis the United States continues to be a heated topic of debate. Though Puerto Ricans hold U.S. citizenship, and thus U.S. passports, and can be drafted into the U.S. military, they cannot vote in federal elections. National plebiscites where residents have been asked to decide whether the island should remain an Estado Libre Asociado (ELA) (Commonwealth), be annexed to the United States as the fifty-first state, or gain national independence have been held in 1967, 1993, and most recently in 1998. Celina Romany writes,

Being neither here nor there, the repeated attempts to redefine the Estado Libre Asociado turn into a pitiful circus, culminating in the *circus maximus* featuring the plebiscite bill. . . . Being neither here nor there, those from *over here* clamor for a ticket to the circus with a passion that wilts in the struggle for participation in the American political process, which daily confirms their second-class citizenship, while those *over there*, staggering in the peculiar ambiguity brought on by colonial hurricane winds, claim the show is sold out. (95)

The national performance of voting in plebiscites enacts the illusion that political self-determination is fundamentally possible and disregards the festering historical and economic currents that determine the available options. The three major political parties in Puerto Rico break down precisely along the lines of the island's status. The Partido Nuevo Progresista (PNP) (New Progressive Party) advocates statehood, the Partido Popular Democrático (PPD)

(Popular Democratic Party) supports maintaining the status quo as an Estado Libre Asociado, and the Partido Independentista Puertorriqueño (PIP) (Puerto Rican Independence Party) supports autonomous independence. In the 1998 plebiscite two new options were made available: Libre Asociación (Free Association), which represents a new alternative, an independent republic associated politically with the United States, and Ninguna de las Anteriores (None of the Above), which came to be known as *la quinta columna*, or fifth column. This fifth option ultimately won the elections with 50.2 percent of the vote.⁸ The paradoxical success of None of the Above and the addition of a new option, Free Association, represent an insistence on rejecting previously imagined solutions. These serve as another example of the articulation of a politics of “not yet” as a response to the existing political strategies for national self-definition.⁹

Just as Chicano identity contains an implicit reminder of U.S. occupation of Mexican lands, Puerto Ricans *en la isla* and in the United States create identities from within the space of U.S. colonization, *en la guagua aérea* of Puerto Rican migration.¹⁰ The geographic distance that separates Puerto Rico from the United States implies a gulf of difference relative to language, culture, environment, and political and economic power. And Puerto Rican identity, whether defined culturally or nationally, must invariably confront the deterritorializing implications of colonization and migratory displacement. In his essay “‘What a Tangled Web!’ Masculinity, Abjection, and the Foundations of Puerto Rican Literature in the United States,” Arnaldo Cruz-Malavé uses the canonical or foundational texts of Nuyorican literature to argue that it “has been written from this *des-tierra*, this landlessness/this banishment, this river of abjection” (237).

These elements—geographic and cultural displacement, desire and rage directed at the colonial metropolis, and the “ruined” formations of a disenfranchised national identity—are central to Nuyorican or Diasporican subject formation. Cruz-Malavé documents how these features of identity often come to be articulated in Nuyorican literary texts through the figure of the male homosexual.

No wonder, then, the insistence on homosexuality in these texts. And if it is true that their characters and poetic personae desperately try to overcome that reversible and ghostly condition that simultaneously emblemizes homosexual practices and the Nuyorican condition, it is also true that they must assume it, incorporate it. . . . To validate masculinity with its ruin, to submit to sodomy, to “buggery,” in order to construct a male national identity, there’s the paradoxical foundational project that Nuyorican texts set for themselves. (240)

This *des-tierro* is also evident on the island as decades of U.S.-orchestrated unemployment and federal dependence, the imposition of English as the second official language of Puerto Rico, forced emigration resulting from past and present U.S. labor policies, U.S. military presence on the island, and disproportionately high Puerto Rican participation in the U.S. armed services continually remind island residents of the material and cultural consequences of their colonial status. Like the main characters in the texts described by Cruz-Malavé, Puerto Ricans here and there are continually getting “fucked” and “fucked over” by the United States.¹¹

This metaphor of sexual submission and conquest echoes the Mexican narratives of *la Malinche*, the emblematic courtesan and translator of Cortés, who came to be known as *la chingada*, or she who gets fucked.¹² Translation, and particularly the role of women and children as translators, is invariably enmeshed in these narratives of colonialism and conquest.¹³ By mediating the space of linguistic difference, translators have often been the symbolic messengers of linguistic and cultural domination. This constant process of mediation is further complicated in a contemporary context by the increasing global mandate of English as the official language of business, scholarship, and international diplomacy, highlighting the relationship between access to language and access to knowledge and power. Bilingualism, or multilingualism, is both a site of privilege that creates access to different discourses and a mark of difference within the English monolingualism of the U.S. state, and very often within the Spanish monolingualism of our own families. The

process of translation involves more than merely translating languages, it involves translating cultures, values, and institutions of power. Multiple, syncretic, simultaneous, contradictory translations of languages and cultures form part of the daily strategies most Latinos/as in the U.S. use to navigate the spaces of work, school, neighborhoods, and families.¹⁴

The question of language and colonization is further complicated within a U.S. context by displacement resulting from generations of immigration—the contemporary cultural consequences of continued U.S. military, economic, and political interests in Latin America or, in the case of Puerto Rico, overt U.S. occupation.¹⁵ Latinas/os in the United States speak or don't speak Spanish, other native languages, and standard English with vastly varying degrees of proficiency. Languages, already accented by regional, cultural, and class differences, become transformed in a U.S. context through their interaction with other languages, accents, and regionalisms.¹⁶ Spanglish in New York's South Bronx is related to the Spanglish of East L.A. only by a shared rejection of "pure" standards of both Spanish and English and the linguistic positionality brought about through (dis)placement.

Rather than a claim to geography or language, others claim *que lo Latino se conoce*, it is an essence that is evident in how we look, talk, dance, eat, play. Is *latinidad* really that easy to spot? How many times have we heard, "She doesn't look Latina"? Who is visible or invisible as a Latina? There are more persons of African descent in South America than in North America, but just how visible are Afro-Latinos in representations of Latina/o communities? In Latino *telenovelas* dark-skinned actors are either invisible or depicted as maids, cooks, and the occasional *santera* or *curandera*, fulfilling the exoticized role of dark spiritual healer for light-skinned protagonists. In the Latin/o American entertainment media, Afro-Latinas/os are visible as singers, athletes, or talk show guests (everyone loves Celia Cruz and Pelé) but rarely as announcers, commentators, or central protagonists. Even in Cuba, which has an established history of at least articulating dialogue on intranational racial politics, media depictions continue to present light-skinned Cubans as the "generic" representative of the nation and Afro-Cubans as something

apart. This has led to what one filmmaker, Pin Vilar, describes as “‘*negrome-traje*’ (black footage): where blacks are depicted in historically specific stories, where race is a central theme . . . but nowhere else” (Mosak 29), perpetuating the centrality of the light-skinned Creole in narratives of *cubanismo*.¹⁷ But aside from daily instances of visual erasure, much of the programming on Spanish-language international stations also recirculates images of shuffling characters in blackface. On the internationally popular show *Sábado Gigante*, broadcast on Univisión, these racially cross-dressed characters make routine appearances, as do “Indians” in full “warpaint” regalia and stereotypical, heavily accented “Confucius”-type characters.

In U.S. media productions depicting Latinos, the circulation of these racialized stereotypes operates on a somewhat different register, attempting to balance the allure of the foreign and exotic with the intelligibility of the familiar as it tries to market itself to both a growing U.S. Latino consumer market and non-Latino audiences. The internationally recognized Afro-Cuban singer Celia Cruz, for example, appears in small acting roles in the movies *The Mambo Kings* and *The Perez Family*, both times playing a *santera*.¹⁸ Meanwhile the current Latin boom in music and film has permitted only the crossover of lighter-skinned performers, and here again almost always within the most sexualized and exoticized terms. Successful dark-skinned Latino actors or musicians are often routinely categorized as African American, ignoring their Latino connections.

In advertisements for North American and European tourist dollars, however, *mulatas* and dark-skinned women play a pivotal role in selling the sexualized exoticism of the Caribbean and the sexual fantasy of a racialized servitude.¹⁹ As Marta Moreno Vega so clearly articulates, within U.S. Latino and Latin American communities, “[t]he image of Black and mulata women remains the sexual, animalistic, primitive creature of desire who is ready to be seduced” (79). Similarly, light-skinned Latinas often fail to fulfill exoticized racial expectations and must therefore continually confront challenges to their status as “authentic” Latina subjects. The intricacies of racialized color, hair, and facial features continue to culturally, socially, and economi-

cally stratify both Latin American and U.S. Latino communities.²⁰ Not surprisingly, many Afro-Latinas in the U.S. also experience the “tug-of-war” between the competing demands of U.S. African American political and cultural movements, Latino movements, and queer and feminist formations. The poet and performance artist Avotcja writes,

Most of the trouble has come from a little tug of war between the self-appointed messiahs of the weekend revolution and the self-appointed messiahs of the Black revolution and the white women’s revolution each of them trying to claim me and pull me apart into little pieces. . . . I’m not ownable. I can’t divide myself into different pieces. I’m not only a lesbian, but also a Rican who happens to be a Black woman. (14)

This passage, published in 1987, speaks directly to the power of discourse to lay claim to the body, to “pull [it] apart into little pieces,” and voices the resistance to that ownership. The wording of the final sentence is also significant, “not only a lesbian . . . who happens to be . . . “ suggests that there is much more of herself than can be contained by these categories or even articulated in her own self-representation.

Latin America and the Caribbean are also home to large diverse Jewish, Arab, and Asian communities, yet almost every Latina lesbian event includes *un homenaje a la Virgen*, the implied assumption being that all Latinas are or were Catholic.²¹ How are Muslim, Jewish, atheist, or Buddhist Latinas made invisible within these Latina lesbian imaginaries? How do women of mixed or multiple cultural heritages negotiate the contradictions and paradoxes of language, ancestry, homeland, and community involved in the deployment and displacement of identity?²²

Identity is more than a list of categories that name our sexuality, gender, HIV status, nation, age, ethnicity, ability, class, language, citizenship status, and religion. Even if we expand the list to include all the other significant features of ourselves, what do these attributes actually explain about our lives? What aspects of identity exceed the categories we have created to

define our places in the world? How do memories of desire and violence mark us in ways that are similar and different from the ways we have been marked by color and gender? How do street corners and kitchen tables, friends and lovers, lullabies and taunts, private violations and public betrayals leave traces on our lives? How do the many moments of our daily existence determine how we view ourselves and the world around us?

Deleuze describes a method of rhizomatic reading and writing that seems particularly useful here. Like the omnipresent *yucas*, *malangas*, and *boniatos* of my homeland, a rhizome can be broken at any point and will sprout anew along old lines or create new “line[s] of flight.”²³ “The rhizome is reducible neither to the One nor the multiple. . . . It is composed not of units but of dimensions, or rather directions in motion. It has neither beginning nor end, but always a middle [*milieu*] from which it grows and which it overflows” (35–36). A rhizomatic reading of *latinidad* suggests the process through which contested constructions of identity work to constitute one another, emphasizing “and” over “is” as a way to think about differences. So *latinidad* is about the “dimensions” or “the directions in motion” of history and culture and geography and language and self-named identities. Even if individual narratives used to chart these discourses contradict or exclude one another, the site of rupture will itself serve as a new site of knowledge production. Of these seeming contradictions, Foucault writes, “they are not two contradictory propositions about the same object, they are not two incompatible uses of the same concept, but two ways of forming statements, both characterized by certain objects, certain positions of subjectivity, certain concepts, and certain strategic choices” (*Archeology* 153). The contradictions revealed in the various constructions of *latinidad* in fact provide the site of intervention where “the ways of forming statements,” the “positions of subjectivity, certain concepts, and certain strategic choices” can begin to be a source of new meanings.

Yet an understanding of the complexities embedded within *latinidad* also makes certain strenuous demands on readers. It calls on what VèVè Clark has

described as diaspora literacy and *marasa* consciousness. She defines diaspora literacy as

a skill for both narrator and reader which demands a knowledge of historical, social, cultural, and political development generated by lived and textual experience. Throughout the twentieth century, diaspora literacy has implied an ease and intimacy with more than one language, with interdisciplinary relations among history, ethnology, and the folklore of regional expression. (42)

Like Clark's *marasa* consciousness, which "invites us to imagine beyond the binary" (43), Anzaldúa's *mestiza* consciousness breaks down the fictions of duality. Anzaldúa does not impose a unity of interpretation, although she suggests a cosmic unity that joins all things, just as Clark's *marasa* consciousness "depends largely on our capacities to read the sign as a cyclical, spiral relationship" (43). Both authors attempt to transcend duality by not only embracing contradiction and ambivalence, but also using them to challenge and transform systems of categorization. Anzaldúa describes the *mestiza* consciousness as "a creature of darkness and a creature of light, but also a creature that questions the definitions of light and dark and gives them new meanings" (81); a constant process of translation and transformation, a movement through and against sites of knowledge. The *mestiza* consciousness she describes is born of hybridity and cross-pollination. She writes, "[t]he work of *mestiza* consciousness is to break down the subject-object duality that keeps her a prisoner and to show in the flesh and through the images in her work how duality is transcended" (80). Anzaldúa invites us to not only "sustain contradictions," but to turn "ambivalence into something else" (79).

Queer Namings

This is not the beginning. I began this chapter with the words *divas, atrevidas, y entendidas*. These are the words, full of *cariño*, that I use for the queer

people I love, the queer person I am.²⁴ *Divas* are a breathing, swishing, eruption of the divine, a way of being in the world, of claiming power as movement, glances, voice, body, and style. *Atrevidas* dare to fulfill desire, challenge assumptions the world has given us. *Entendidas* share a knowledge, understand the significance and nuances of queer subaltern spaces. These identities are rich and real for me. They resonate with an attitude that steps beyond sexual practice or sexual identity into the realm of a politicized passion for liberation and empowerment. These terms also mark a language that is foreign to dominant linguistic norms. They are culturally specific in ways that are not about a discourse of nation or blood but about the language of barrios and bars. *Divas, atrevidas, y entendidas* are all gendered in the feminine, yet they are available to whoever dares to occupy them. In Spanish, there is no direct translation for “queer.” These words speak to something that is both the same as and different from “queer”: attitude, defiance, knowledge, the excesses of categories.

This breaking down of categories, questioning definitions and giving them new meaning, moving through spaces of understanding and dissension, working through the critical practice of “refusing explication” is precisely what queerness entails. “Queer” is not simply an umbrella term that encompasses lesbians, bisexuals, gay men, two-spirited people, and transsexuals; it is a challenge to constructions of heteronormativity. It need not subsume the particularities of these other definitions of identity; instead it creates an opportunity to call into question the systems of categorization that have served to define sexuality. There is already something “queer” about categories such as lesbian or gay, “inclusive disjunctures” that simultaneously employ speech and silences on sexual practice, desire, identification, anatomy, gender, community, and dare I say love.

In *Bodies That Matter*, Judith Butler analyzes the critical uses of “queer” and the implications raised by its deployment. She argues that while “it is necessary to assert political demands through recourse to identity categories, and to lay claim to the power to name oneself and determine the conditions under which that name is used, it is also impossible to sustain that kind of

mastery over the trajectory of those categories within discourse" (*Bodies* 227). We may deploy language and categories but we can never fully possess them.

If the term "queer" is to be a site of collective contestation, the point of departure for a set of historical reflections and futural imaginings, it will have to remain that which is, in the present, never fully owned, but always and only redeployed, twisted, queered from a prior usage and in the direction of urgent and expanding political purposes. (*Bodies* 228)

The deployment of language as an identity practice only becomes accentuated when it steps across linguistic and cultural boundaries. Butler questions how "'queer' plays—or fails to play—within non-white communities" (*Bodies* 228). Yet, for most Latinas/os living in the United States, the appropriation of language for our own uses forms part of the rituals of survival. Like "queer," the words Chicano, Pocho, and Nuyorican entered the vernacular with decidedly negative connotations, which were then appropriated and transformed within these communities. Queer becomes but one more in a series of terms we can employ to define ourselves. There are others, each ripe with possibilities. *Entender*, literally "to understand," has long served as a code word to define those who are "in the know." In their introduction to *¿Entiendes? Queer Readings, Hispanic Texts*, Bergmann and Smith write of the term,

"Understanding" is clearly a cultural, not a natural category: it cannot take place outside of defined social structures. It is also a matter of knowing, rather than being: a woman or a man can be married and straight identified, but still be "wise" to same-sex culture. Finally, it is not an identity but an activity, requiring at least two partners in order to take place.

Hence, both in the written texts of queer activism and in the oral tradition of lesbian and gay slang, Spanish speakers may have anticipated the critique of identity and community implicit in much recent Anglo-American queer theory. (12)

The idea that understanding “requires at least two” suggests the relationality and relativity of sexually nuanced cultural knowledge as a practice that informs the interactions between the self and the other. *Entender* is a queer social practice of translating and interpreting sexual codes.

De ambiente is another term popular among Latinas/os within and outside the United States. Literally “of an ambiance or environment,” it is a term that speaks to a larger sense of community and belonging, not of a specific sexual practice or identification. Comparable to the popular African American term “in the life,” it suggests participation in a subaltern space that is coded by cultural knowledge, and sexual and social practice within specific communities. In certain circles, however, the term *de ambiente* has taken on a certain bourgeois connotation, a social identity associated more with the milieu of discotheques and discrete private gatherings than with a politicized and visible street presence. This instability in meaning represents another instance of the ambiguous nuances of naming as a marker of political and individual identity.

Nevertheless, naming as an identity practice has a broad range of expression in Spanish; the many words we call ourselves reflect an acquired ease with the manipulation and transformation of language. The highly gendered nature of Spanish also creates the possibility of code switching between masculine and feminine forms of address as a spontaneous critical and imaginative practice of queering language. Some particularly lyrical examples include *tortillera*, from the image of making tortillas where a flipping is involved, as a metaphor for lesbian sixty-nine; *buchota*, a Spanglish version of butch; *marimacha*, from María and a feminization of *macho*, used for butch women or sometimes dykes in general; *mariquita*, ladybug, but also a diminutive form of *maricón*, faggot; *reina*, queen, but not necessarily a drag queen, as it is also used as a term of endearment within and outside queer contexts; *bollera*, from *bollo*, which means a bread roll in most of Latin America but in Cuba it also means vagina; the suffix “*era*” as in *tortillera* implies an agent and is used for practitioners of female-to-female sex, possibly also suggesting a meatless sandwich; *maricon*, dyke or faggot, a feminization of *maricón*, fag-

got; *vestida*, literally meaning “dressed,” which is commonly used for drag queens; *papi*, daddy, which unlike its use in s/m communities, where it generally signals a specific sexual/social role, in Spanish is most often used as a term of endearment for a butch (male or female) lover or friend; the term *mami* is also a popular term of endearment applied without regard to biological sex in queer Latino communities, but similarly nuanced by gender. Latinas/os in the United States also make full use of English words such as butch, femme, dyke, faggot, drag queen, dramadiva, switch, top, daddy, leather mistress, do-me queen, and a plethora of other terms.

Political and social group names, past and present, also incorporate the playful and imaginative qualities of language. These include the now defunct transnational Latina lesbian magazine entitled *Esto No Tiene Nombre* (This Has No Name), but also meaning something fabulous or scandalous beyond words; El Closet de Sor Juana, a collective in Mexico City (The Closet of Sor Juana), a reference to the early Mexican feminist nun, Sor Juana Inéz de la Cruz, who is widely known for lesbian references in her work; Salpafuera, from *sal pa[ra] fuera* (come out, but also slang for a big to-do), a multi-gender collective in San Juan, Puerto Rico, which plays with Puerto Ricans’ characteristic chopping off of final syllables or consonants; the name of an international Latina lesbian magazine, *conmoción*, means an emotional commotion, but also can be broken down to literally mean with motion; Brujas (witches) in Medellín, Colombia; Colectivo Gestación (Gestation Collective); the National Latina/o Lesbian and Gay Organization in Washington, DC, uses the acronym LLEGO, or “arrived”; *Musas de Metal* (Metal Muses), a women’s radio program; the group Himen (Hymen) and its publication *LESVOZ* (pronounced Lesbos, which combines Les and voz [voice]), all in Mexico City and the now defunct CURAS: Comunidad Respondiendo a AIDS/SIDA (Community Responding to AIDS/SIDA) in San Francisco, the acronym drawing on the double meaning of the word *curas*, meaning healings and priests. These are conscious manipulations of oral and written language, which often reflect the specific cultural, ideological, and/or linguistic context in which they occur. For example, the Miami-based magazine *¡Perra!*

includes a definition of the word *perra* (literally a female dog or bitch) in its credits page:

PERRA es . . . en nuestro español caribeño, una palabra de exaltación para todo aquello que sea fabulosamente atrevido. Puede ser perra alguien, una voz, un vestido, un peinado, una canción, un show, un logro o una expresión. Para leernos, ¡tienes que ser PERRA! (¡Perra! 2)

(*PERRA* is . . . in our Caribbean Spanish, a word of exaltation for all that is fabulously daring. *Perra* can be a person, a voice, a dress, a hairdo, a song, a show, an act, or an expression. To read us, you must be *Perra*!)

The oral quality of the word itself also benefits from the Cuban propensity for accentuating rolling r's. Many of the groups also add a form of translation or subtitle to their names. For example, the magazine *¡Perra!* includes the descriptive phrase "Vida y cultura gay latina de Miami" (gay Latin life and culture of Miami). Not all names are as playful; for contrast let me also mention the group Seminario Marxista Leninista Lésbico Feminista de Guadalajara (Marxist Leninist Lesbian Feminist Seminar of Guadalajara).

Yet most group names employ imaginative linguistic play, creative gender twistings, and the subversive appropriations of previously negatively intoned words. They also demonstrate the narrative elements of naming and vividly illustrate naming as an identity practice. There are no easy equivalents, direct translations, or clear definitions for any of these terms, and in fact they reveal very little about the complexities of sexual desires and practices or the political postures of the groups they name. These words can only be read and understood in relation to the context in which they are articulated, and even then only partially. Samuel Delany writes, "Gay Identity . . . is an object of the context, not of the self—which means, like the rest of the context, it requires analysis, understanding, interrogation, even sympathy, but never an easy and uncritical acceptance" (32). That identity is "of the context [and] not of the self" highlights the interrelationality between sub-

ject position and the “situated contemporaneous horizon of meanings”—bodies and sites.

Within this conceptualization of language, identity becomes an act of storytelling constructed through memory, naming, and shifting language practices. Lisa Kahaleole Chang Hall suggests,

Gay men and lesbians are the people of drama. I have a theory that gay identity is really founded on storytelling and gossip, not sex, that in fact people often have sex so that they can talk about it. From the moment of that first entry into “the community” or “the life,” we’re embedded in a legendary network of gossip, tale-telling, and multiple interpretations of the same events. . . . Identity becomes an art form at times, a pastiche of meanings, affiliations, and self-parody that can be baroque. (229)

And identity as an “art form” always remains open to reinscription and reinterpretation.

Within the emerging field of queer Latino studies, critics of various disciplinary persuasions have been dutifully engaged in our own sets of identity practices through our acts of interpretation, inscription, and naming. Institutional spaces, such as universities and publishing houses, are also discursive spaces where articulations of academic identity are framed within parameters that simultaneously demand both innovation and adherence to established norms. As academics, working within the liberal or limiting confines of our specific departmental and disciplinary mandates, often we have had to have our critical projects positioned within recognizable (and tenurable) taxonomies of scholarship. Generally these investigations have been received as discipline-specific: literature (Foster, Yarbrow-Bejarano,) theater (Muñoz, Román), history (Chávez-Leyva, D. J. González).²⁵ Yet most of these texts invariably bleed into other disciplinary contexts. In José Esteban Muñoz’s *Disidentifications*, performance is read through the texts of popular culture, photography, and politics rather than solely through the scripts of the theatrical stage. José Quiroga begins his text *Tropics of Desire* with Latin

American literature and deftly dances through readings of La Lupe and Ricky Martin to end on a discussion of local queer U.S. Latino politics. Whether in single-author texts or edited volumes on queer Latino sexuality and identity, traditional disciplinary boundaries become inadequate containers for subjects whose lives and utterances traverse the categories meant to contain them.²⁶

This observation will surprise no one, and should not be misread as the result of a current academic trend toward dismantling traditional disciplines, but instead as an ongoing impulse toward a radical rethinking of taxonomies of knowledge. In years past, texts such as Moraga and Anzaldúa's *This Bridge Called My Back: Writings by Radical Women of Color* (1981) or Ramos's *Compañeras: Latina Lesbians (An Anthology)* (1987) were already rejecting established academic and literary precepts by combining personal essays, poetry, multilingual writing, history, and artwork that theorized the texts of lived experience. And much of the queer Latina scholarship that has responded to these creative intellectual movements has likewise been invested in the disruption of borders of genre, language, disciplinarity, and geography. Consider the 1984 article by Lourdes Arguelles and B. Ruby Rich, which critiqued the white gay media's accounts of the Mariel boatlift by analyzing émigré enclaves in the United States, Puerto Rico, México, and Spain, combining personal observation with Cuban cultural history and political and social analysis. Or more recently, Yarbrow-Bejarano's essay "Crossing the Border with Chabela Vargas," which traverses geographies of Costa Rica, México, Spain, and the United States, combining close readings of visual images, lyrics, and musical history, to discuss the production and consumption of culturally gendered representations of the erotic. As an object of study, queer *latinidad* demands a practice that moves across geographic, linguistic, and imaginary borders, not simply because it is more provocative to do so, but because the very disciplines that divide Latin American from North American, music from literature, politics from performance, or queer studies from Latino studies have been based on paradigms constituted through our marginalization. My own text attempts to examine what happens when discourses of identity

traverse these borders of inquiry. I consider disciplinary instability not as an inevitable consequence of queer Latina subjectivity, but as the underlying premise through which the complexities of identity can begin to be understood.

Bodies and Landscapes

The subjects presented in this text are all “subjects-in-process,” yet my understanding and analysis can only be read as an attempt to assign meaning to subjectivity in practice, a moment that is frozen in a text and reemerges as a fluid substance through reading and interpretation. Like a series of photographs in a gallery, the chapters in this text bring bodies and landscapes together to explore how they work in unison to create the discursive effect of figures and shadows, stasis and movement, strategy and risk. Yet I also want to leave a space available for the insertion of that “something else” that eludes language, the spark-spirit-chi-soul that gives cadence to that which constitutes the excesses of subjectivity, the *mojo* that flavors rhizomatic intentions.²⁷ The effect of a complete picture is wholly illusionary. The configurations are intentional and self-serving; other combinations are present even through their omission. Each subsequent chapter approaches the task of naming spaces and practices differently. Each discursive space I depict carries with it a different opportunity to construct *latinidad* and queerness, to employ difference and contradiction “as tactical interventions in the other mobility that is power” (Sandoval 225 n. 25).

Like Quiroga, I find that

My interest is less in theorizing on the present state of gay studies than in moving about, creating a book that is a sort of traveling and movable object, one that shows and tells at the same time. I think this is the queer praxis that should animate gay and lesbian studies—the space where theory and practice meet in order to open new possibilities (8).

Yet this praxis also conditions a methodology that is grounded in an analysis of the demands each of these spaces places on the subject. Understanding how identity practices operate within these different sites requires a theory and practice that are both situated in a specific localized time-space framework and cognizant of the fact that each new combination of circumstances and readings will yield different interpretations. Each chapter functions as a case study of localized sites and practices—specific subjects engaged in negotiating a particular discursive space under a unique set of circumstances. The shift from one theoretical or disciplinary space to another “is not seamless; indeed, the interstice, the discontinuity, the gap is precisely a site of textual production: the historical and ideological moment in which the subject inscribes herself” (Alarcón, “Anzaldúa’s” 44). In law, for example, subjects must conform to established rules that construct identity within a “single-axis analysis” that erases the “intersectionality” of mutually constructed discourses (Crenshaw 139–40). In the spastic spaces of the virtual world, imagination and language become the tools through which subjectivities are articulated. In the Internet chatrooms of cyberspace, if you can write it, you can be it, changing your ethnicity, gender, age, measurements, even species with a keystroke.

Within much postcolonial and poststructuralist criticism, space has replaced time as “the most important ordering concept of reality” (Ashcroft et al. 37). Questions of space and place are accentuated in the analysis of performance and agency. It is the time-space matrix that is most useful to an analysis of site-specific practices. Such an understanding requires an analysis of the relationships within and between different localized discursive sites, different disciplines, different sites of knowledge production. Thus capital, heteronormativity, (post)(neo)colonialism, the AIDS pandemic, patriarchy, and the postnuclear age must serve as the “contingent currents” of ideology or the ubiquitous frame that informs any localized practice.

In *Mapping the Subject*, Pile and Thrift chart the contemporary theoretical uses and definitions of space, location, the subject, and metaphors of movement and travel through the texts of British cultural studies. They also re-

mind readers that the critical emphasis on routes and travel, nomads and exiles must be continually read against a landscape of economic, social, and political restraint and confinement. They argue that subjects are not preexisting but are derived in practice, a practice based on the specificities of place.

[T]here is a major emphasis in theories of practice on the specificities of place. Particular contexts are crucial elements of the practical sense because dispositions have to be constantly tuned to the indeterminacy of each context, often in creative ways, so the “rule” never stays quite the same. In other words place is constitutive of the subject’s understanding of the world. (29)

Their theorization of subjects derived in practice has resonance with Alarcón’s “subject-in-process.” They state that a subject’s understanding comes from the “continuous flow of conduct through time and space constantly interpellating social structure” (3). Alarcón’s analysis goes further, however, to claim that these interpellated social structures remain operative even if they fail to fully determine the boundaries of subjectivity or agency. She writes, “the very contingent currents through which the geopolitical subject-in-process is dislocated and forced into (im)migration will retain an irreducible difference that refuses to correspond neatly to the subject’s account of herself and the theory we produce to account for her appearance” (“Conjugating” 138).

By focusing my study on discursive spaces (activism, law, and cyberspace), I complicate facile constructions of location, community, and positionality. These spaces have already been disciplined by the discourses that constitute them, and which create and cut off possibilities of identity practices. Each requires a different methodological practice for understanding the relationship between bodies and sites. Each chapter functions as a case study of a particular localized instance of subjects’ engagement with a particular set of discursive and ideological (pre)conditions. The texts and sites I have selected are not meant to be either representative or exemplary. Instead, I have

self-consciously chosen situations that illustrate the shifts, gaps, and fissures in discourses of identity. I begin with activism because most of the critical work on identity has focused on its political and strategic uses in the struggle to bring about social change. Political activism within queer Latina/o communities also provides insight into the larger social and historical context through which other articulations of identity can be read. Identity politics, for example, constitutes a body of knowledge with specific historical investments for marginalized groups in this country. I focus the chapter on activism on the work of Proyecto ContraSIDA por Vida (Project Against AIDS for Life), a Latina/o HIV prevention social service agency located in San Francisco's Mission District. Through an examination of its programming and cultural production, I reveal its seeming investment in both a deconstruction and a rearticulation of identity politics. I suggest that the agency is remapping identity as something that is "in-process" rather than knowable or definable through static categories.

The chapter on law forecloses the possibilities of playful crossings. Law is already set up as a rigid discursive site wherein performance and language practices are structured to create conclusions about identity. Here, the subject is continually being constrained by the mandates of legal discourses. The subject is obligated to perform, and performance exacts a price; the risk is carnal. The case under consideration involves a gay Brazilian living in San Francisco who seeks political asylum in the United States based on sexual persecution in his native country. The "real-life" significance of borders and nations is acted out in a courtroom drama while the narratives invoked resonate with other discourses of persecution and freedom, identity and practice, savagery and civilization.

The chapter on cyberspace explores the possibilities and implications offered by self-constructed online identities. Here identity is reduced and/or multiplied by the enactment of language practices. Cyberspace is assumed to be a place where identity is always under erasure; at the same time, it is a space that facilitates other formations and representations of identity. The

fact that the virtual is by definition not the carnal is the limit that troubles both its possibilities and its limitations.

The space of place is itself a precarious ideological construction. Attempts to situate each of these chapters within specific localized sites require vastly different configurations of spatiality. In the chapter on activism, place is geographic: Proyecto ContraSIDA por Vida is located at a busy intersection in the heart of San Francisco's Mission District. It also suggests how the spaces of community and neighborhood function as sites of ideological contestation. For the chapter on law, place is reduced to the space of a courtroom, the exact site where the text of the narrative, the court transcript, is produced. Yet what Tenório's narrative chronicles is precisely the interstitial space of the refugee, a place that is neither here nor there but is nevertheless mired in narratives of north and south, the United States and Brazil, San Francisco and Rio de Janeiro. The virtual space of the Internet is seemingly nowhere and everywhere simultaneously, yet it is accessed through the personal space of my home computer. The terms "queer" and "Latina/o" also shift in meaning as they move through these sites, from the multiethnic, multicultural, multi-gender site of Proyecto ContraSIDA por Vida, to the specifics of a gay Afro-Brazilian immigrant from Rio de Janeiro, to my own queer femme interactions with the multinational, multigender, multilingual virtual world that sits at my desk. Each of these spaces creates and forecloses distinct identity and narrative practices.

Discursive spaces are not autonomous; they are permeable and heteroglossic. They seep into one another, contaminating and enriching ideas and disciplines. There is a continual movement as individuals, texts, and ideas migrate across spaces, informing and transforming knowledge production. Although each of the spaces I present provides a unique set of conditions for the performance of identity practices, there is also an overarching relationship between these domains of knowledge. Repressive laws work to create the political conditions for grassroots activism; activists utilize the tools of literature, theory, and art to counteract dominant representations;

new technologies are employed by all sides to disseminate information and images; scholarship reinscribes all of these practices with old and new meanings. The languages of activism, law, academia, and technology are never fully contained; instead they tunnel into one another, remapping the disciplinary terrains they encounter. There is an extensive intertextuality between and among these spaces and their inhabitants, community activists who are also undocumented residents, filmmakers who are also students, administrators who are also DJs, academics who are also sexualized virtual beings and embodied social dreamers.

My thesis contends that language practices exist in relation to the discursive spaces in which they occur. Therefore, my own narrative practice attempts to enact these shifts as it moves through the chapters from one discursive and disciplinary field to another. Each discursive site under consideration, and each corresponding chapter, performs its own definition of queer *latinidad*. As I document and enact the limits and possibilities each of these three spaces provides for the articulation of subjectivity, there is also a fourth discursive dimension at play: the language of academia itself. While at times I may appear to be pushing at its seams, this text remains immured by its trappings, bound to a set of investments that can never fully escape the hold of the institutions that authorize me as an academic subject. Rather than the facile disavowal or deprecation of the academic project, I want to suggest that it too can exist as a site of co-optation, collusion, resistance, and transformation. While throughout these pages I may seem to be documenting how others maneuver the discursive spaces of activism, law, and cyberspace, this text is also the product of my own negotiation of the contours of academic discourse, my own modest attempt to reenvision the prickly practice of scholarly inquiry.